

ON FURTHER INTEGRATING INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY OR ACADEMIC DEBATE

Timothy M. O'Donnell

Competitive academic debate is not an island unto itself. Despite the fact that the form and function of a contest round has remained relatively stable for the past several decades, the game itself has changed dramatically and there has been no greater change agent than technology. Some of these new technologies are products of the debate community such as computerized tournament tabulation and commercial online evidence databases. Many others are products of the information revolution such as photocopiers, electronic research resources, mobile computing, and the products of the wireless revolution. Collectively, these technologies have had a significant, unmistakable, and “profound” (Southworth, 1997) impact on competitive academic debate even if they have not substantially improved the “quality of debate” or addressed problems such as “dwindling participation” (Morello, 1986, p. 68)

Although some previous commentators¹ have, for a variety of reasons including issues of access, ethics, and practicality, been less than sanguine about the impact of technology on debate, I am far more enthusiastic. To begin with, technologically induced change is inevitable and whether we like it or not, the advent of new technologies will change the nature and form of the debate activity despite well intentioned regulations. There is a perceptible generational gap between members of the debate community with respect to individual's facility and capacity to deploy and use new and emerging technologies. Increasingly, our universities are populated by members of the “net generation” – a generation of students who come to our campuses with an intuitive and well

honed set of digital literacies. Yet, not only is change inevitable, integration of technology and academic debate also offers tremendous promise for enhancing, expanding, and elevating academic debate. In what follows, I outline my views regarding what we can and should do as individuals and as a community to encourage and shape the transformation of debate.

First, to propel further integration we need to create a reward structure for early adoption of new and innovative uses of technology in intercollegiate debate. So far, a sense of civic duty, competition, and, in a few cases, profits have proven to be powerful sources of motivation for innovation and early adoption. However, under such circumstances widespread adoption and subsequent innovation depends upon the good will of unselfish individuals. For example, computer tabulation programs and on-line archives of both arguments and tournament results, each of which has had a substantial impact on academic debate, have been the product of countless hours of work by only a few individuals. We should do more to create a system of incentives and rewards for efforts like these to propel further integration of technology and debate. For example, while the debate community has a number of mechanisms to recognize excellence in coaching or community service, no such means of recognition exists to acknowledge achievements or breakthroughs related to technology. Creating such an award is, however, only a first step. Members of the debate community and its various professional associations should spearhead efforts to secure long term funding to support innovative projects which integrate debate with the latest advances in technology. Such funding exists, yet there has been little set aside to lead invention.

Second, we need to share new and innovative uses of debate technology more widely. Space and time should be carved out of tournament schedules for discussion and sharing of new and innovative uses of technology. Similarly, sessions should be organized at academic conferences and debate association meetings exclusively devoted to discussing and advancing best practices. A central online forum or message board exclusively

devoted to debate technology should be created as a means for sparking discussion and assisting with trouble shooting.

Third, we need to do more to prepare and equip academic debate for the “net generation.” As Oblinger and Oblinger (2005) point out, this generation of students will bring to our campuses a wave of learners who, among other things, are digitally literate, connected, immediate, experiential, social, team oriented, visual and preoccupied by things that matter. We should not expect academic debate to remain insulated from these emerging modes of learning and we do so only to our own detriment. Just as our teaching colleagues across campus are being challenged to adapt to the learning styles and demands of their students, we too are similarly challenged. The silver lining in all of this is that debate itself is already well suited to the characteristics of and learning styles demanded by the net generation. In fact, academic debate offers an organized environment that is ready made for the net generation if we are sufficiently engaged and prepared to scale-up our community.

Fourth, we need to create partnerships with leaders in information technology both on our own campuses and at the national level. Such alliances would not only more widely disseminate what members of the debate community have accomplished to outside audiences but they also would provide valuable avenues for stimulating and propelling further innovation at the intersection of technology and debate. In my experience, the IT professionals at our home institutions are at the forefront of incorporating new and emerging technologies in the classroom and beyond. Not only do they find many of the innovations which have occurred in the debate community fascinating and cutting edge, they have the ideas and resources to help us do even more. But to do so, we need to start the conversation and let them know both what we are doing and what we would like to do.

Beyond the confines of our individual institutions intercollegiate debate needs to forge alliances with organizations like EDUCAUSE, the national leader in advancing the “intelligent use of information technology” in higher education [www.educause.edu]. By involving ourselves in this larger national

conversation, we not only advance and promote debate, but we also tap into a vast network of stimulation, enrichment, and possibility. To begin with, such a connection offers many possibilities for supporting and stimulating the research and development of information technologies for debate. In addition, each year, EDUCAUSE organizes a variety of conferences and workshops which convene IT leaders in higher education. Members of the intercollegiate debate community should represent academic debate in these events because there is both much to showcase and much to learn. In addition, such engagement offers a greater opportunity for reflection, analysis, insight and assessment on how we in debate are doing at integrating new and merging learning technologies and practices into the debate activity.

Fifth, we need to actively use technology to invent, experiment with, and study a variety of new and innovative formats. Although new technologies have changed debate in profound ways over the past few years, the form and function of the debate round and tournament has remained relatively stable. However, advances in information technology offer a host of possibilities for rethinking what it means to debate. For example, the advent of Multi-User Virtual Environments (MUVEs) such as Second Life coupled with ubiquitous computing open up a range of possibilities for radical experimentation which was inconceivable only a few years ago. Second Life is one of the most popular 3-D virtual worlds and it has been built and owned by the collective efforts of nearly 3 million people worldwide. Business and education inhabitants are increasingly using it for real time collaboration, communication, teaching, and research on a variety of topics while politicians are starting to use it for virtual town hall meetings. Today, MUVEs make national (and international) tournaments without travel not only conceivable, but imminently practical. In addition, the format of a debate round has, with only minor modification, remained largely static for much of the past century. Ultimately, the time for an evaluation of our format is long over due and technology offers a variety of mechanisms for doing so. Throughout this period, careful consideration of what we may gain as well as what we may lose will be crucially important.

Finally, and most importantly, we need to be dedicated to preserving, protecting, and promoting public understanding of debate in general and academic debate in particular. In an increasingly connected and wireless world, academic debate will be incapable of remaining the closed and “insular” enclave of “specialized academic activity” that it has been for so long (Mitchell, 2000, xvii). Already, videos of intercollegiate debates have appeared on such internet video sharing sites such as YouTube and Google Video. Consequently, the ability to distribute both the best and the worst of the debate product, in real time, to a global audience, ensures a future of both promise and pitfall. In my view, as both individuals and as members of a larger community we need to be mindful of the consequences and possibilities of dramatically expanded audiences while we take an active role in shaping the academic debate narrative. Such mindfulness entails, among other things, serious reflection on the merits of the deployment of momentary argument styles and practices for situated competitive success in a world where the insularity of the activity has been punctured by the omnipresence of long digital shelf lives and more universal audiences. Never before have we had the ability to undermine/promote public understanding of debate in such far reaching and consequential terms. New information technologies make such a process all but inevitable and the principles and values we use to manage academic debate’s transition to a techno-global world will ultimately determine the future direction and sustainability of the activity itself. Ultimately, we need thoughtful, careful, and most importantly, ongoing deliberation and research among academic debate’s stakeholders on the further integration of information technology and academic debate.

Note

1. See, for example, the Winter 1986 issue of *Speaker and Gavel* which contains several essays evaluating the promise and peril of the applications of computer technology in intercollegiate debate. Reading this collection two decades hence reveals a confounding paradox of so much, yet so little

change regarding information technologies impact on academic debate. The issues and positions inscribed in those essays appear at once antiquated, prophetic, and unfulfilled.

References

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Timothy M. O'Donnell is Director of Debate and Associate Professor of Speech Communication, University of Mary Washington.

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